

Royal patronage and tragedy

Mendelssohn's brilliant career brought him into contact with many notable people, among them King Frederick William IV of Prussia. In 1842, the king gave him a letter to deliver to his cousin Prince Albert in England and in this way Mendelssohn met the British royal family. Queen Victoria and Prince Albert (see [box](#)) were great admirers of his work and the three of them became friends, making music together in Buckingham Palace on several occasions.

Mendelssohn's grueling workload took a toll on his health and by the beginning of 1847 he was visibly ill. When Fanny died suddenly in May that year, it was a shattering blow, and he survived her by only a few months, dying—after suffering a series of strokes—in Leipzig on November 4, aged 38. His body was taken by train to Berlin where it was buried alongside his sister's. Tragedy struck again six years later when Mendelssohn's widow, Cécile— a clergyman's daughter whom he had married in 1837—died of tuberculosis, leaving their orphaned children to be brought up by relatives.